ClearGround

US Property Contamination Intelligence

"Know what's in your ground before you buy it"

$3B+	US environmental due diligence market
0	Competitors at the intersection of consumer SEO + contamination API
275K	Programmatic pages from day one
4x	AI agent productivity multiplier (Anthropic internal measurement)

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Executive Summary

Every US property transaction involves contamination risk, but no company provides continuous, property-level contamination scoring as both a consumer product and a B2B API. ClearGround fills this gap.

ClearGround is a property contamination intelligence platform that cross-references 15+ federal, state, and local environmental databases to generate a contamination risk score for any US property address. The platform serves three markets simultaneously:

- **Consumer SEO surface** -- 275,000 programmatic pages covering every US ZIP code, city, county, and water utility. Monetized through affiliate partnerships (water filtration, home testing kits, insurance).
- **Property risk reports** -- detailed contamination analysis for individual addresses. Free basic score, paid detailed report ($29-99). Target: homebuyers, real estate agents, inspectors.
- **B2B API** -- RESTful property-level contamination risk data for real estate platforms, insurance underwriters, mortgage lenders, and environmental consultants. $2K-25K/month.

$13-33K	$95-270K	< $4K
MRR by Month 12	MRR by Month 24	Monthly operating costs

The timing is driven by three simultaneous regulatory forces: EPA PFAS drinking water regulations (effective 2026-2029), stricter lead pipe replacement rules, and insurance market hardening that is creating urgent demand for property-level contamination data. This is the same market dynamic that allowed First Street Foundation to build a $71M company providing flood risk scores -- but applied to the contamination data gap that nobody is filling.

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Market Analysis

The contamination data gap

The US environmental due diligence market exceeds $3 billion annually. Every commercial real estate transaction requires a Phase I Environmental Site Assessment. Residential buyers increasingly demand environmental risk information. Insurance companies are repricing policies based on contamination proximity. Yet the data infrastructure underlying all of this is fragmented, outdated, and inaccessible.

Environmental data in the US is spread across 50+ federal databases, 50 different state systems, and thousands of county-level records -- all with different formats, different APIs, and different update schedules. No single platform cross-references all of these into a unified, property-level risk score.

Why now: Three regulatory catalysts

EPA PFAS Regulations (2026-2029)
Maximum contaminant levels for 6 PFAS compounds in US drinking water. All 50,000+ water utilities must test and potentially remediate. Property owners near contamination sources face value depreciation. Creates massive demand for PFAS proximity data.

Lead and Copper Rule Improvements (2024)
All lead service lines must be replaced within 10 years. 9.2 million US homes still have lead pipes. Homebuyers need to know lead risk at the property level.

Insurance market hardening
Insurers are re-evaluating contamination-adjacent properties. The same pattern that drove flood risk data adoption (First Street Foundation) is now playing out for contamination risk.

Target addressable market

Segment	Market Size	Our Target (Year 2)	Revenue Model
Consumer SEO (affiliate)	$1B+ water filter market	500K monthly visitors	$15-40K/mo affiliate

Segment	Market Size	Our Target (Year 2)	Revenue Model
Property reports	$3B environmental due diligence	5,000-15,000 reports/mo	$30-80K/mo reports
B2B API	$500M+ property data market	10-30 API customers	$50-150K/mo API
Government contracts	$200M+ EPA/state budgets	2-5 contracts	Upside potential

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Competitive Landscape

Climate risk for properties is red ocean. Contamination risk is blue ocean. The critical distinction: well-funded competitors (First Street, CoreLogic, Cape Analytics) focus on climate/natural hazard risk. Nobody owns property-level contamination intelligence with both a consumer and B2B surface.

Direct competitors

Competitor	What They Do	Weakness	Threat Level
EDR / Lightbox	Environmental database reports for Phase I ESAs. $500-600/report	Per-report model, no continuous monitoring. No consumer play. Reports are PDFs, not APIs. Legacy business.	Medium
First Street Foundation	Flood, fire, wind, heat risk scores. Free consumer + paid API. $71M raised.	Climate-focused only. Does NOT cover contamination, PFAS, Superfund, water quality.	Low (different niche)
CoreLogic	$6B company. Property data for title, insurance, real estate.	Generalist. Contamination is not a priority product line. Enterprise-only, no consumer.	Low-Medium
EPA/FEMA tools	Free government databases (Envirofacts, Cleanups in My Community)	Terrible UX. Fragmented across agencies. No cross-referencing. No property-level scoring.	Very Low
EnviroSite	Environmental due diligence reports	Old-school per-report model. No tech platform. No SEO surface.	Low

The blue ocean position

ClearGround occupies a position that no existing player covers: the intersection of **property-level contamination risk** (not climate risk), delivered as **both a consumer SEO product and a B2B API**, built on **autonomous AI agents** that can maintain 50-state data pipelines at a fraction of the cost of a human data team.

The closest analogy is First Street Foundation's journey with flood risk. In 2015, flood data was fragmented across FEMA, state agencies, and local records. First Street built a unified platform, got adopted by Realtor.com and Redfin, and built a $71M company. Contamination data is in the same state today that flood data was in 2015. ClearGround is the First Street for contamination.

Defensibility layers

- **Data aggregation moat:** 50-state data integration is painful and time-consuming. Each new state added makes the dataset more valuable and harder to replicate. Early mover advantage compounds daily.
- **SEO moat:** 275,000 pages of unique, data-rich content. Organic traffic is free and compounds. A VC-funded competitor would spend on sales teams, not SEO -- different acquisition channel.
- **AI cost advantage:** Autonomous agents maintain the data pipeline at ~10% of the cost of a human data team. This makes us structurally profitable at revenue levels where a traditional competitor would still be burning cash.

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The Product

ClearGround is a three-layer platform. Each layer builds on the previous one, creating multiple revenue streams from the same underlying dataset.

Layer 1: Consumer SEO Surface

Purpose: Free organic traffic. Brand building. Affiliate revenue.
Timeline: Months 1-4
Revenue: $3-8K MRR by month 6 (affiliate)

Programmatic pages for every US ZIP code (41,000+), city (30,000+), county (3,100+), and water utility (150,000+). Each page contains unique, data-driven contamination risk information: nearby Superfund sites, PFAS likelihood, water utility compliance history, industrial facilities, underground storage tanks.

This is an execution of the same playbook proven with TapWater.uk in the UK market, where programmatic water quality pages have achieved strong organic rankings and affiliate revenue. The US market has 5-10x the search volume and higher affiliate CPMs.

Target keyword clusters

Keyword Cluster	Est. US Monthly Searches	Competition	Monetization
"is my tap water safe"	40,000+	Low-Medium	Water filter affiliate
"[city] water quality"	500,000+ (combined)	Medium	Filter + testing affiliate
"PFAS in water / PFAS near me"	90,000+	Low (growing fast)	Filter + insurance affiliate
"water quality by zip code"	25,000+	Low	Testing kit affiliate
"Superfund sites near me"	30,000+	Very Low	Insurance + testing
"PFAS contamination map [state]"	50,000+ (combined)	Low	Filter + insurance

Layer 2: Property Risk Reports

Purpose: Direct revenue. Lead qualification for B2B.
Timeline: Months 4-8
Revenue: $5-15K MRR by month 12

Comprehensive contamination risk score for any US address. Free basic score drives traffic and email capture. Paid detailed report ($29-99) includes: contamination sources within radius, historical industrial use, water utility compliance details, PFAS likelihood, lead pipe probability, radon zone, and actionable recommendations.

Layer 3: B2B API

Purpose: High-value recurring revenue. Enterprise relationships.
Timeline: Months 8-14
Revenue: $50-150K MRR by month 24

RESTful API providing property-level contamination risk data. Target customers: real estate platforms (Zillow, Redfin, Realtor.com), insurance underwriters, mortgage lenders, environmental consultants, proptech startups. Pricing: $2K-25K/month based on query volume. The pitch to these customers: "You show flood risk from First Street. Your users also need contamination risk. We are the First Street for contamination."

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Data Architecture

All data sources are publicly available and free to access. The value is not in data exclusivity but in comprehensive aggregation, cross-referencing, geocoding to property level, and continuous updating. This is the moat.

Source	Data	Format	Coverage
EPA ECHO	Facility compliance, violations, inspections	REST API	All US
EPA Superfund / CERCLIS	Contaminated sites, cleanup status	REST API + CSV	All US
EPA Brownfields	Former industrial sites	REST API	All US
EPA TRI	Toxic Release Inventory per facility	CSV downloads	All US
EPA SDWIS	Safe Drinking Water violations	REST API	150K+ water systems
USGS	Groundwater quality measurements	REST API	All US
State UST databases	Underground storage tanks	Varies by state	50 states, 50 formats
State PFAS results	PFAS testing in water, soil	Varies by state	~30 states
FEMA flood maps	Flood zones (correlates with contamination spread)	API + shapefiles	All US
Census / ACS	Housing age, demographics (lead risk proxy)	REST API	All US
DoD PFAS sites	Military base contamination sites	Published list	700+ sites
FAA airports	PFAS from firefighting foam (AFFF)	Database	All US airports
County assessor data	Parcel boundaries, well vs. municipal water	Per-county	3,100+ counties

Technical stack

The architecture mirrors the proven TapWater.uk stack, adapted for US scale:

- **Database:** Supabase (PostgreSQL + PostGIS) for spatial queries and property-level geocoding
- **Frontend:** Next.js on Vercel for programmatic page generation and API layer
- **ETL pipelines:** Python data ingestion, initially supervised, transitioning to autonomous agent-driven
- **Geocoding:** Property-level address matching using Census TIGER/Line + county parcel data
- **Scoring engine:** Multi-factor contamination risk score combining proximity, severity, source count, and regulatory status across all integrated databases

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The AI Thesis

Why next-generation models change the economics

Anthropic's Claude Mythos Preview system card (April 7, 2026) reveals a model that achieves 93.9% on SWE-bench Verified (real-world software engineering), can work autonomously for hours on complex tasks, and delivers a measured 4x productivity uplift for technical staff. When this capability class reaches the public API, it fundamentally changes what a solo operator can maintain.

What we build now vs. what changes with Mythos-class models

Task	Current Model (Opus 4.6)	With Mythos-Class Models
Federal data pipelines	Fully capable. Well-documented APIs.	Same. No change needed.
State data integration (50 states)	Possible but requires significant supervision per state.	Autonomous: describe the data source, agent figures out the format and builds the pipeline.
Continuous data monitoring	Requires manual scheduling and error handling.	Agents autonomously check all 50+ sources, process changes, flag anomalies.
County-level data (3,100+ counties)	Impractical at scale with current supervision needs.	Agents can independently tackle each county's unique format. Full coverage becomes feasible.
Cross-domain risk scoring	Rule-based proximity calculations.	AI-driven synthesis across disparate sources. Better scores than simple proximity.
Broken scraper repair	Manual diagnosis and fix.	Agents detect and autonomously repair broken data pipelines when source formats change.

The economic impact

Without AI agents, maintaining 50-state data pipelines + a 275K-page site + a B2B API would require an estimated 5-8 full-time data engineers and content specialists. Annual cost: $600K-1.2M in salary alone.

With Mythos-class AI agents, a single technical operator can maintain the same scope. This creates a structural cost advantage: ClearGround can be profitable at revenue levels where a traditionally-staffed competitor would still be burning cash.

5-8 FTEs	1 person	$600K+
Traditional team required	With AI agent leverage	Annual cost savings

This is the thesis. The AI capability leap doesn't just make things faster -- it makes a category of business viable for a small team that was previously only viable for a well-funded company. We build the foundation now with current models, and deploy autonomous agents for full coverage when Mythos-class capabilities reach the public API.

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Financial Model

Revenue projections

Revenue Stream	Starts	Month 12 MRR	Month 24 MRR
Consumer SEO (affiliate)	Month 4	$3K - $8K	$15K - $40K
Property reports ($29-99)	Month 6	$5K - $15K	$30K - $80K
B2B API ($2K-25K/mo)	Month 9	$5K - $10K	$50K - $150K
Total MRR		$13K - $33K	$95K - $270K

Key assumptions

- US environmental/water quality keywords have 5-10x the search volume of UK equivalents
- Programmatic SEO playbook is proven (TapWater.uk demonstrates the model works)
- B2B pricing is conservative -- EDR charges $500-600 per single report; our API provides continuous access
- Property report conversion: 1-2% of visitors at $49 average price point
- B2B customer acquisition: 1-3 new customers per month starting month 9

Cost structure

Cost Item	Monthly (Year 1)	Notes
Supabase / Vercel hosting	$200 - $500	Proven stack from TapWater. Scales well.
Geocoding APIs	$300 - $500	Census geocoder is free. Supplementary services for edge cases.
Claude API (agent pipelines)	$500 - $2,000	Scales with data sources integrated.
Domain + misc. SaaS	$100 - $200	Registrar, email, monitoring.
Total monthly costs	$1,100 - $3,200	Excludes founder salary.

Margin profile: Data businesses have 80-90%+ gross margins once the pipeline is built. ClearGround's AI-driven maintenance model keeps costs nearly flat as revenue scales. Breakeven on operating costs is achievable within months 4-6. Profitable including reasonable founder salary by months 8-12.

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Go-to-Market

Phase 1: Foundation

Timeline: Weeks 1-8 **| Status:** Build now

- Federal data pipeline -- ingest EPA ECHO, Superfund, TRI, SDWIS, Brownfields, FEMA into PostGIS/Supabase
- Geocoding + contamination risk scoring engine -- property-level multi-factor score
- Next.js site architecture + programmatic SEO framework on Vercel
- First 5 state integrations (CA, TX, FL, NY, PA) -- largest real estate markets
- Deploy first 10,000+ ZIP code pages with real contamination data

Phase 2: Traffic + First Revenue

Timeline: Weeks 8-16 **| Status:** Build now

- Scale to 275K programmatic pages -- all US ZIP codes, cities, counties, water utilities
- Affiliate monetization -- water filter partners, home testing kits, insurance comparison
- Basic property report -- free contamination score, paid detailed report ($29-99)
- Email capture -- "Get notified when contamination risk changes at your address"
- Begin SEO authority building with data-driven content + PR outreach to environmental journalists

Phase 3: B2B + AI Scale

Timeline: Weeks 16-36 **| Status:** Build when Mythos-class API available

- Deploy autonomous agents to integrate remaining 45 state data systems
- Build continuous monitoring across all data sources
- Launch B2B API -- RESTful property-level contamination risk
- Outreach to proptech platforms, insurance insurtechs, real estate data aggregators

• Approach Zillow / Redfin / Realtor.com as contamination data provider (they already show flood risk)

Phase 4: Expand + Compound

Timeline: Months 9-18 **| Status:** Growth phase

• Government contracts -- EPA, state environmental agencies, municipal planning

• White-label reports for real estate agents (branded contamination reports for buyers)

• International expansion -- EU PFAS regulations create same demand in Europe

• Adjacent data products -- air quality, soil contamination, industrial noise, EMF

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Risks and Mitigations

An honest assessment. These are real risks, not boilerplate.

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
CoreLogic or First Street enters contamination data	High	First-mover advantage compounds daily through SEO authority and data breadth. They would need 12+ months to build what we build in 6 with agents. Our cost structure also lets us undercut on API pricing.
Data quality / liability exposure	High	Clear disclaimers: "Informational purposes only, not a substitute for Phase I ESA." Same legal approach as Zillow's Zestimate or First Street's flood scores. We present data, not professional assessments.
VC-funded startup enters the niche	Medium	Programmatic SEO moat is organic, not paid. VC-funded competitor would spend on enterprise sales, not SEO -- different market segment. Our AI cost advantage means we are profitable where they burn cash.
Scraper fragility (state sources change format)	Medium	Mythos-class agents can autonomously detect and fix broken scrapers. Monitoring + alerting pipeline catches breakage within hours.
EPA builds a better public tool	Low	Government tools are consistently poor UX. They do not cross-reference sources. Our value is synthesis + UX + property-level scoring, not raw data.
AI capability timeline uncertainty	Medium	Phase 1-2 (consumer SEO + reports) are achievable with current models. Mythos-class agents are needed only for Phase 3 scale (50-state coverage). The business is viable even if agent capabilities are delayed.

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Why This, Why Now

The case for ClearGround rests on five converging factors that create a narrow window of opportunity:

1. Regulatory tailwind is unprecedented

PFAS regulations, lead pipe rules, and insurance market hardening are creating simultaneous, urgent demand for contamination data. This is not a speculative market -- the regulatory deadlines are set and the compliance obligations are real. Companies and homeowners need this data now.

2. The data gap is real and verified

No existing platform provides continuous, property-level contamination risk scoring with both a consumer surface and a B2B API. EDR/Lightbox sells $500 PDF reports to environmental consultants. There is no "First Street for contamination." We have validated this gap.

3. We have a proven playbook

TapWater.uk demonstrates that programmatic environmental data pages drive organic traffic and affiliate revenue. The architecture (Next.js + Supabase/PostGIS + Python ETL) is proven. The SEO methodology is proven. We are applying a validated model to a market 10-100x larger.

4. AI agents make this economically viable for a small team

The Mythos system card documents a 4x productivity uplift and autonomous multi-hour task completion. This means one technical operator can maintain data infrastructure that traditionally requires 5-8 engineers. We have a structural cost advantage that makes us profitable where competitors burn cash.

5. First-mover advantage compounds

Every day of data collection, every page indexed by Google, every state data source integrated makes the moat deeper. The SEO authority compounds. The data completeness compounds. A competitor starting 12 months later faces a 12-month SEO gap and a 12-month data gap. The window to establish this position is now.

The ask: Dedicated founder time to execute Phase 1-2 (8-16 weeks) to validate US market traction. Initial investment is minimal -- hosting costs under $3K/month, no external funding required. Success criteria: 100K monthly organic visits and $10K MRR within 6 months, proving the model before scaling to Phase 3-4.

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